Each of us was given a room with an attached bathroom. There was a cot, a bed sheet and a pillow. Was there a blood stain on the bed sheet? I was not sure then, but soon I would see many such patches on curtains and linen on the furniture. Malligai had a history of being a torture house. Were these telltale marks of third-degree measures that accused in many cases were subjected to? Or were they just props to scare you so the interrogators could get the accused talking without having to try too hard? I was not sure.

Probably because it was a Saturday that we arrived, for two days there was not much of questioning. The next round of action was to begin on Monday.

12 December 1994. It was night by the time a constable asked me to go meet M L Sharma in a room upstairs. Seated opposite to Sharma was a man in a grey safari suit. He wore a black 'tilak' that devotees got from Ganapathi temples in Kerala. He looked perturbed.

Sharma offered me a seat.

'Do you know him?' he asked me.

'No.'

'Take a close look at him, you may be able to identify him.'

I looked at this man again.

'No, I don't know him,' I said.

Now Sharma turned to the man and asked him if he knew me.

'Yes,' said the man in the suit. 'He is Nambi Narayanan.'

I was surprised—and worried if this was another ploy to implicate me in the case by producing a false witness.

Sharma asked, 'For how long had you known him?'

'Oh, I've never met him,' said the man in the suit. 'I've seen his photograph in the newspapers in connection with the ISRO spy case.'

I was relieved.

Sharma introduced this man to me as Raman Srivastava, the inspector general of police, Kerala. We shook hands.

The CBI officer turned to me.

'But then, during the IB interrogation you gave a statement that you knew Raman Srivastava.'